

Governing the 'barbarians'

Alexander's treatment of the 'barbarians' he conquered varied. After the capture of Sardis (334BC) he followed a policy of 'appeasement' in his relations with native peoples. He posed as a liberator from the sometimes intolerant rule of the Persians by:

- using existing forms of government where possible, as well as local and respected leaders
- showing respect for the religious and political institutions of the native peoples. For example, he visited the Oracle of Zeus Ammon at Siwah (331BC) in Egypt and his recognition there as the son of the god ensured his acceptance as the new pharaoh
- granting religious freedom and encouraging racial tolerance. His adoption of Persian dress (331BC) and court customs, rebuilding the temple of Bel Marduk in Babylon, marriage to Roxane (328BC) and the marriage ceremony between local women and Greek soldiers at Susa (324BC) are good examples of this
- including Persians and Greeks within the government, either as satraps or as members of the army
- establishing over seventy cities or colonies throughout the empire
- introducing a uniform currency to foster trade within the empire.

Lydia

Alexander 'freed' the Lydians and allowed them to use traditional laws. A Macedonian, Assander, was made satrap and was given a Macedonian force to garrison the area. A Greek, Nicias, was appointed as a financial official.

Caria

Alexander was welcomed as a liberator. The rightful queen, Ada, was restored to her throne and a Macedonian garrison was left. With characteristic political tact, Alexander used the locals' anti-Persian feelings to win them to his side. After Ada's death, Alexander inherited the kingdom—she officially adopted him—and sent out a governor to take her place (Arrian, 1.24). Judea was given some freedom. The high priests were allowed to govern according to their own laws.

Egypt

The administration of Egypt was special. The Egyptians had rebelled against the Persians, and surrendered to Alexander without a fight. This may explain his enthusiastic acceptance of Egyptian tradition—unlike the Persians. His political tact and opportunism once again showed through.

Arrian (3.5–6) gives us an account of Alexander's administration of Egypt. Two Egyptians, Doloaspis and

Petists, were appointed as nomarchs (magistrates) to control the civil administration of Upper and Lower Egypt. Native customs and laws were to be followed. Alexander's portrait even appears in the Temples of Luxor as a pharaoh in traditional style. His aim was to win the affection of the native people and to become popular.

The military administration of Egypt was kept separate, under Macedonian control. The areas east and west of Egypt were placed under separate control again. Libya was under the command of Apollonius, and an Egyptian Greek, Cleomenes of Naucratis, controlled Arabia by Heropolis. Cleomenes was also in charge of the collection of the taxes from Egypt. Native tax collectors were used. Thus Egypt was securely held, without the reasons for rebellion that had existed under Persian rule.

Babylon

Like Egypt, Babylon had resented Persian rule. Local religion, the worship of Bel Marduk, had been stopped and the temple destroyed. The Persian satrap, Mazaeus, surrendered the city without a fight. Alexander, again showing his diplomacy, honoured the local priesthoods and ordered the rebuilding of the temple (Arrian, 3.16). Mazaeus was reappointed satrap and allowed to continue minting coins. (Mazaeus apparently had two sons with

Review and analyse

- What problems did Alexander have to overcome in order to control his empire?
- Why did Alexander use different systems of government in different areas?
- Why did the Egyptians and the Babylonians accept Alexander as a 'liberator'?
- How did Alexander administer his empire? Under a heading for each area make notes on the systems he used.

Alexandria in Ptolemaic times

